

LOWS

▼ Snowballing of the fertiliser crisis in June, where police firing at a peaceful rally killed a farmer.

▼ Serial blasts in Bangalore in July, a total of nine, that left one dead and 20 injured. The police have not made too much headway yet.

▼ Around 20 churches and prayer halls were attacked over two subsequent Sundays by Bajrang Dal activists. The state Government did not swing into action soon enough.

▼ The state home minister, instead of taking a stand on attacks against Christians, tried to downplay the incident leaving the Government red-faced.

▼ The handing over of the administration of the Shree Mahabaleshwara temple of Gokarna to a private mutt sparked widespread protests among workers and devotees. The Government had to retract its move.

the last few weeks. Even as the party was formulating election strategy in Bangalore during its national executive meet, the Sangh Parivar members were attacking churches and prayer halls in three districts of the state.

What followed was a comedy of terrors. First, the Government decided to take a tough stand on forced conversions, citing that as the reason for the attacks. While, for three days, Mangalore, Udupi and Chikmagalur saw Hindu and Christian groups clashing, the state Bajrang Dal chief, Mahendra Kumar, proudly announced that he was masterminding the attacks. To add to that, the state home minister decided to downplay the incident by writing, "No one was killed. Why the fuss?" It

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CLASH OF FAITH: Policemen outside St James Church after it was vandalised in Bangalore

was only after a missive from the Centre that Kumar was arrested even as attacks continued the following Sunday in churches in the state capital. The publicly upset archbishop of Bangalore, who refused to accept a bouquet of flowers from him and made his disappointment clear, and a Centre ruled by an opposition party that was too eager to send a team to inspect the region, also didn't help Yeddyurappa's cause.

With such "emotional issues" taking centre stage during Yeddyurappa's rule, the worst casualty has been his development plans that have completely gone unnoticed. For example, he has drawn up a Rs 1,800-crore Agenda for Bengaluru Infrastructure Development, a knowledge council, and a vision group called Karnataka 2020 that will decide the agenda for how people want to see the state 12 years from now. At the same time, he's building airports in tier II towns such as Raichur, Bagalkot, Davangere and Kushalnagar for better connectivity. While

the world judges him harshly for deciding to be a right-winger first and then a chief minister, Yeddyurappa is quietly working on the areas he considers his strengths—financial planning and rural organisation.

The chief minister, of course, feels victimised. "The Centre is too eager to find fault with us. The prime minister refused an audience with me the last time I had gone to Delhi," he says. If there is a wily old fox underneath Yeddyurappa's pristine white safari suit, it doesn't come out very often. Mostly, it is either a man wronged, or a man in duress. He is a leader who is just learning the usefulness of being well-prepared.

The realisation has certainly come with

the knowledge that he has to be himself. He is not Modi. He cannot throw caution to the wind and still come out unscathed. He cannot yet aspire to be the suave national leader ("I have been given the responsibility of strengthening the party in Karnataka. No other plans.") because his rusticity is his biggest calling card now. He cannot relegate the strong opposition, which consists of former prime minister and the state's grand old man H.D. Deve Gowda's JD(S) and the Congress, to the junkyard of inconsequence. He doesn't want to relive his tag as the "seven-day chief minister" like last year, when the JD(S) had unceremoniously withdrawn support and left him high and dry.

Yeddyurappa knows that as a leader, he has to back his people ("Our home minister is doing a good job"), but he is also playing on his image of an understated leader ("My work will do the talking"). He knows that he cannot afford to let hype get in the way if he has to be in power for a long innings. ■